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The Significance of Exams and Certificates in Vocational Education and Training (VET) in Costa Rica

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Abstract

Context: The economic progress of Latin America depends not least on the availability of an efficient pool of skilled labour. In the current discourse, dual vocational education and training (VET) is particularly seen as a panacea against structural labour market and social problems. The Costa Rican government's latest initiative to implement dual VET dates back to 2016. In light of this, a bilateral agreement on international cooperation in VET was concluded with the German government. However, it should also be noted that attempts to transfer German dual VET to other countries often fail. Therefore, this study is mainly concerned with describing the social acceptance of VET programmes, educational qualifications and their examination modalities at the upper secondary level in Costa Rica. Both exclusively school-based and dualized VET programmes will be considered. Furthermore, the significance of the respective qualifications for access to the labour market will be critically examined.
Approach: This study chose a multidimensional methodological approach, which includes desk research, document analyses, and the screening of cultural artefacts. In addition, empirical data was collected through group interviews and participant observation. The transcribed audio material was analysed using QDA software in accordance with the Grounded Theory Methodology (GTM), both deductively and inductively, following the coding paradigm.
Findings: The participant observations and group interviews with various stakeholders of the Costa Rican VET system show discontent with the current VET programmes and final exams. Employers criticise a skills mismatch. Representatives of trade unions and companies are often unfamiliar with the new dual VET programmes or have prejudices. It is also apparent that employers have little inclination to become actively involved in dual VET and examination processes. At the same time, employees of the Costa Rican Ministry of Public Education (Ministerio de Educación Pública, MEP) find it difficult to involve other stakeholders in the organisation of vocational training and examinations.
Conclusions: The social acceptance of VET is always related to the respective context and access mechanisms to the labour market. Thus, VET and such programmes and certificates appear to be the second-best choice in Costa Rica at best compared to general and tertiary education. Up to now, the development and implementation of VET programmes and the corresponding final exams have been the sole responsibility of the MEP. As part of the development and execution of the newly implemented dual modalities, the MEP is attempting to involve other stakeholders. However, it is currently unclear which stakeholders should be involved. Full participation based on the consensus principle, as is the case in Germany, for example, could change the collective perception structures regarding VET within Costa Rican society in the future. The involvement of actors from the private economy, in particular, could contribute to this to a large extent, as their function as gatekeepers puts them in a position of power. After all, they usually regulate access to gainful employment.

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Keywords

vocational education training, VET, Costa Rica, certificates, social acceptance

1 Introduction

The economic progress of the Latin American region depends not least on the availability of an efficient pool of skilled labour. Along with the increasing technologization of most industries comes an increased need for engineers and technicians. Higher education and vocational schools, in particular, should therefore be supported financially and geared towards such requirements (Katz, 2023).

The postulate that the vocational education training (VET) sector should be aligned with such requirements is anything but new. The World Bank discussion paper from 1990 already recommended investing more in VET. However, this referred less to full-time school programmes - as they predominate in Latin America - as these tended to be considered too expensive and inefficient (Haddad et al., 1990). Then as now, the focus is much more on VET programmes, some of which take place in companies and therefore have a stronger connection to the world of work than full-time school programmes (Álvarez-Galván, 2015). In this regard, the transfer of dual VET modalities from Germany is, at times, the centre of interest (Gessler et al., 2019).

For Latin America, de Ibarrola (2016) states that some countries, such as Brazil and Mexico, have implemented dual VET programmes with varying degrees of success. In Costa Rica, numerous endeavours to establish such programs have been undertaken historically. The most recent initiative by the Costa Rican government to implement dual Vocational Education and Training (VET) dates back to 2016. Consequently, a bilateral agreement on international cooperation in VET was formalized with the German government in 2019 (GOVET, 2019). Following a pilot phase, dual VET programmes (Educación y Formación Técnica Profesional Dual, EFTP Dual) were increasingly integrated into the existing vocational education system (Láscarez Smith & Baumann, 2020). Costa Rica currently offers VET programmes at three levels (Rommel & Vargas Méndez, 2022):

1. at upper secondary level at the vocational schools (Colegios Técnico Profesionales, CTP-MEP) of the Ministry of Public Education (Ministerio de Educación Pública, MEP);
2. at the National Institute of Apprenticeship (Instituto Nacional de Aprendizaje, INA);
3. in tertiary education at para-universities, at the National Technical University (Universidad Técnica Nacional, UTN) and at the Technological Institute of Costa Rica (Instituto Tecnológico de Costa Rica, TEC).

To date, no dual-structured VET programmes have been offered at educational institutions in the tertiary education sector.

In the current discourse, dual VET, in particular, is seen as a panacea against structural labour market and social problems (Álvarez-Galván, 2015; UNESCO, 2019). However, it should also be noted that attempts to transfer German dual vocational education training to other countries often fail. This is certainly due, among other things, to structural and institutional differences between the education system in Germany and that of the countries mentioned. However, another possible cause could also be the generally negative image that is attached to vocational-technical training programmes in these countries (Allais, 2020; Clement, 2014).

This study is mainly concerned with describing the social acceptance of VET programmes, educational qualifications and their examination modalities at the upper secondary level in Costa Rica. Both exclusively school-based and dualized vocational education and training programmes will be considered. Furthermore, the significance of the respective qualifications for

access to the labour market will be critically examined. The following research questions serve as guidance:

- What is the social significance of vocational education and training, as well as the corresponding educational qualifications and their examination modalities in Costa Rica, and what is the significance of these qualifications for accessing the labour market?
- How is the current examination system organised in Costa Rica, and what instruments are used to measure performance?
- To what extent do Costa Rican stakeholders in initial vocational education and training see a need for reform of the examination system in relation to dual training programmes?

The following section reflects on the first research question and asks about the social significance of vocational education and training in Costa Rica. This is followed by a description of the examination system in vocational education and training at the upper secondary level in Costa Rica. In the fourth section, the methodology and the survey sample are outlined, and selected results are presented and discussed. Finally, the conclusion and outlook are presented.

2 Social significances of vocational education and training in Costa Rica

In highly unequal societies of the Global South, vocational education and training and the corresponding certificates often only have limited significance and are, at best, a second-best choice compared to general education or higher education programmes (Allais, 2020; Clement, 2014). According to Allais (2020), the generally negative social connotation of VET and the resulting low symbolic value of the corresponding certificates in the countries mentioned, especially the former colonies, has deep roots in the history of this very colonialism.

The social inequalities from the colonial era continue to influence the country to this day and manifest themselves, for example, in the high level of income inequality[1] (OECD, 2023). With the aim of reducing these social inequalities, a vocational education system was implemented in Costa Rica in the 1950s, which particularly addresses vulnerable social groups (Beirute Brealy, 2018). However, the goal of social transformation has been undermined by liberalisation efforts in Latin America since the 1970s, according to Katz (2023). Allais (2020), for example, also argues that the still prevailing - and in some cases accelerating - inequality structure in the global South leads to competition for educational credentials. This competition, in turn, reinforces a societal preference for general and tertiary education certificates while at the same time stigmatising and systematically weakening more practice-oriented VET - to the detriment of economic development.

The Costa Rican economy is currently suffering from a shortage of skilled labour and high unemployment among young people. At the same time, it appears that the vocational education system is weakened. Against this background, Álvarez-Galván (2015) formulated recommendations in the 2015 OECD report on Costa Rica with the aim of strengthening both the vocational education system and the labour market. Following this publication, the Costa Rican government at the time implemented various of these recommendations. For example, a national qualifications framework was designed and implemented (Marco Nacional de Cualificaciones de la Educación y Formación Técnica Profesional de Costa Rica, MNC-EFTP-CR) and

[1] Costa Rica currently has the highest income inequality in the OECD comparison. However, it is important to note that many Latin American countries are not members of the OECD. Costa Rica, therefore, performs much better in a Latin American comparison.

various dual VET programmes were newly developed and installed alongside the full-time school-based programmes (see also Camacho Calvo, 2023; Láscarez Smith & Baumann, 2020).

The integration of dual training programmes as a further option in the existing vocational education system, which until then had mainly comprised full-time school-based programmes, as mentioned above, was a top-down implementation by the previous Costa Rican government (Camacho Calvo, 2023; Láscarez Smith & Baumann, 2020; Láscarez Smith & Schmees, 2021).

As part of the implementation of such dual training programmes in Costa Rica, the involvement of possible social partners, i.e. employers' and employees' associations, was considered from the outset (Láscarez Smith & Schmees, 2021, 2023). However, company participation in the dual training programmes remained rather modest, probably also because the implementation was mainly initiated by the state. Another major problem was being able to approach potential training companies in the first place. One reason for this is probably the strong fragmentation of the business sector. In Costa Rica in particular, in addition to formally registered companies, there are a large number of companies that can be categorised as belonging to the informal sector. There is also a dichotomy within the country between an economically strong centre (Gran Área Metropolitana, GAM) and an economically weak periphery (Arce Brenes & Villalobos Chacón, 2021; Rivera, 2022).

The organisational structures of workers are similarly heterogeneous. There are associations of solidarity movements (Asociaciones del Movimiento Solidarista), cooperative organisations, but also trade unions, for example. However, trade unions have a relatively weak position in the private economic sector. One reason for this weakness is likely to be the systematic dismissal of unionised employees by employers (Thannhäuser, 2020; Valverde Rojas, 1993). Secondly, these trade unions were never able to assert themselves in the Costa Rican private economic sector due to the strong presence of solidarity movements. These associations are made up of employers and employees. However, the control and administration of these associations lie mainly with the employers and the employees close to the employers. Ultimately, these associations promote a discourse within Costa Rican society that tends to be anti-union (Valverde Rojas, 1993).

In contrast to the trade unions in the private sector, the teachers' unions can be considered fundamentally strong. However, the attitude of two teachers' unions - the Asociaciación Nacional de Educadores (ANDE) and the Asociación de Profesores de Segunda Enseñanza (APSE) - was strongly opposed to the introduction of dual VET programmes. The transfer of parts of the vocational education and training programme to companies was feared to lead to large waves of teacher dismissals. It was also feared that the deployment of apprentices in companies would be less about training and more about the exploitation of students as cheap labour in companies (APSE, 2019; ANDE, 2023; Láscarez Smith & Schmees, 2023). The APSE's tough oppositional stance (towards dual VET programmes) also manifested itself in quite high-profile actions, such as demonstrations, but also in the form of caricatures or other cultural artefacts (APSE, 2019). In contrast, the Sindicato de Trabajadoras y Trabajadores de la Educación Costarricenses (SEC) was one of the supporters of dual VET from the outset (SEC, 2022).

Nevertheless, the overall context described above shows that the establishment of dual VET programmes encounters considerable difficulties. This is mainly because it requires the interaction of various stakeholders, each with different interests: companies, trade unions and the government. Depending on the occasion, reaching a consensus between all parties involved is a time-consuming process in terms of both content and time. Indeed, after the change of government, the so-called round table in 2017, at which the former government, employer and employee representatives were to be persuaded to engage in trialogue, failed (Láscarez Smith & Schmees, 2021, 2023).

Ultimately, it can also be stated that the implementation of the national qualifications framework has had little resonance on the Costa Rican labour market. The possible reasons for this are varied and complex and cannot be fully described and analysed here. Some aspects have already been briefly outlined above, such as the considerable fragmentation of the labour market (informal vs. formal sector, periphery vs. centre, etc.), whereby there are hardly any institutionalised mechanisms for closing the labour market. For example, no formal and conclusively certified vocational education or other specific certificates or evidence are required to set up a business in Costa Rica. Business start-ups in both the informal[2] and formal sector are possible at any time and by anyone. Nevertheless, start-ups are often micro-enterprises[3] that are located in the informal sector. In addition, the problem is emerging that técnicos in the sense of skilled workers, are competing with informally qualified craftsmen (oficios) in the labour markets (Hunink & Raesfeld, 2022, 2024; Hunink et al., in press). This leads to the conclusion that investment in VET does not necessarily pay off for individuals in Costa Rica.

However, the absence of institutionalised mechanisms of labour market closure in Latin America is not synonymous with a lack of social norms and conventions that structure the labour market. Instead, all labour markets, including informal ones, are determined by social rules and norms. In this context, the enormous relevance of social contacts[4] is emphasised for Latin America and other countries in the Global South (Pries, 2019). Vocational education and training certificates, on the other hand, play a subordinate role (Allais, 2020; Clement, 2017; Hunink & Raesfeld, 2022, 2024; Hunink et al., in press):

> The demand from companies for graduates of this type of school generally remains limited because, below the level of academic qualifications, recruitment often works informally less along the lines of educational qualifications than through acquaintances. (Clement, 2017, p. 17; translation by author)

The relevance of social contacts in the labour markets of the Latin American region is also reflected in empirical studies. In this context, there is also a reference to ritual kinship (apadrinamiento) (Clement et al., 2021; Hunink & Raesfeld, 2022, 2024; Hunink et al., in press), as a kind of "symbolic extension of the family" (Hunink et al., in press) takes place in various areas of life, including work contexts. Although the empirical studies mentioned were carried out in Mexico, it is reasonable to assume that due to a similar history, the relevance of informal training and work settings and the lack of institutionalised closure mechanisms, the Costa Rican labour market is determined by equivalent patterns of behaviour (Clement et al., 2021; Hunink & Raesfeld, 2022, 2024; Hunink et al., in press).

3 Examination system in vocational education and training at upper secondary level in Costa Rica

The Ministry of Public Education (Ministerio de Educación Pública, MEP) is the authorized institution with regard to the development of final examinations. The development process of the final examinations to date is institutionalized, timed and comprises various phases. The employees of the Quality Management and Evaluation Department (Dirección de Gestión y Evaluación de la Calidad, DGEC-MEP) of the MEP are solely responsible for developing the

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2 Currently, 43.9% of the working population in Costa Rica is employed in the informal labour market (INEC, 2022).

3 According to Rivera (2022), the majority of newly established micro-enterprises in Costa Rica fail within the first few months of being founded.

4 This resource is also relevant in Germany. However, there are indications that the qualitative characteristics are different.

elements of the multiple-choice exam and the corresponding specification table. The teachers at the vocational schools do not develop or validate the test. They are only involved in the process of validating the specification table.

Currently, all final examinations for VET at the upper secondary level in Costa Rica are measured using multiple-choice tasks. This means that performance assessment is knowledge-oriented and does not primarily focus on competencies. However, according to de Ibarrola (2016), the didactic principle of competence orientation and the associated methods, such as project-based learning, have been increasingly discussed in the Latin American region for several years. As a result, innovative forms of performance assessment in examinations are also necessary in the future. A revision of performance assessment in final examinations, particularly for the dual training programs in electrical engineering and web development (MEP, 2022), is currently being planned by the MEP.

It becomes evident that the content of final exams can vary depending on the didactic principle applied. Their significance for the VET programme and the individual development options associated with them are also very diverse in different VET sub-systems within Costa Rica, but also worldwide. Despite this diversity, examination formats and, above all, VET certificates have similarities in terms of their functions. In addition to providing individual feedback to teachers and learners, they also have a signalling function for the labour market. Furthermore, certificates are often linked to access options for further education and the vocational education system (Severing, 2011). Consequently, the issuing of VET certificates is essentially aimed at regulating access to the respective labour market and ultimately bringing about its social closure. Nevertheless, the function of VET certificates - despite their theoretical coherence - depends to a large extent on their collective social acceptance.

4 Methodological approach and sample

A multidimensional methodological approach was chosen for this study. This is spread across different research methods, such as desk research in the form of extensive secondary and document analyses. This includes reports, articles, etc. In addition, cultural artefacts such as caricatures, novels, etc., are examined, as these allow an alternative approach to the respective cultural context (Hunink, 2021; Lueger, 2010; Lueger & Froschauer, 2018). In addition, empirical data is collected in the form of group interviews and participant observations. The participant observations took place in 2023 in the context of meetings of the MEP and various organisations and institutions. The group interviews were also conducted in 2023 at the vocational schools CTP San Pedro de Barva and CTP Atenas. The focus was on the apprentices, teachers and coordinators of the 1st generation of dual VET programmes. The sample consists of ten apprentices and eight teachers, coordinators and school management from CTP de Atenas in the field of electrical engineering. In addition, the eight trainees and seven teachers and coordinators from the CTP San Pedro de Barva in the field of web development were included in the group interviews. The transcribed audio material was analysed using QDA software in the research style of the Grounded Theory Methodology (GTM), both deductively and inductively. The coding paradigm is followed in the sense of open, axial and selective coding, whereby the categories of ideas of ideal examinations and stakeholder perspectives on vocational education and training are presented for reasons of space (Strauss & Corbin, 1996).

5 Presentation and discussion of the results

Discussions with MEP employees and group discussions with apprentices revealed a certain level of discontent with the current final examinations. After all, only formal knowledge is tested and no focus is placed on vocational competences. When asked what examinations in dual training programs should ideally look like, one apprentice responded as follows, with the other participants in the group interview nodding in agreement:

> I think maybe it would be helpful to develop some kind of practical project [in the final exam] that incorporates the knowledge we gain in the apprenticeship, I don't know. Maybe it would help if we go beyond writing or completing exams and demonstrate our competencies [through practice]. (CTP Atenas, pos. 554-558)

The group interviews with teachers and coordinators show that the strongly knowledge-orientated final examination in the form of multiple-choice tasks contradicts their didactic understanding. Instead, they would like to see final examinations that focus more on professional competences, which is something they have in common with the MEP employees and apprentices interviewed:

> For me, it would be better if something is obviously worked on, with all the steps involved in a project. This is especially the case in this field [web development], as there are many topics that can be developed for a project. So I would put it into practice, wouldn't I, that they are implementing something? Because they [the apprentices] have to analyse. They have to organise. They have to implement. (CTP San Pedro de Barva_Educadores, pos. 881-885)

Teachers also say that, in addition to such a practical examination, it would be useful to hold oral examinations in the form of a technical discussion. After all, this could ensure that the apprentices have really got to grips with the subject matter:

> I1: It's like a presentation, like an oral exam where he explains.
> I3: He interacts. Yes.
> I5: Exactly, exactly. And you can really see, and you can really see if the student has internalised the knowledge or sought it out? (CTP San Pedro de Barva_Educadores, pos. 951-957)

The current Costa Rican teacher training programme for vocational schools does not deal specifically with the pedagogy and didactics of VET (Rommel & Vargas Méndez, 2022). Nevertheless, the interviewed teachers describe the ideal examination based on the didactic principle of competence orientation. This is probably due to the fact that the majority of the teachers worked in the private sector before working at school, which is why they are familiar with the corresponding organisational logic.

Employers notice a discrepancy between the formal knowledge acquired in educational institutions and the actual competence requirements in companies (skills mismatch) with regard to full-time school VET programmes. In addition, the general attitude towards the técnico IV[5] vocational education and training certificates seems to be one of scepticism, which manifests itself in a widespread and dismissive statement about it: intermediate technician, or half technician.

The participant observation at various sessions with representatives of trade unions and the corporate sector revealed that few of those present were aware of the MEP's dual training programmes. This could be due to the fact that these programmes are relatively new. In addition, there are still prejudices against the dual VET programmes on the part of some trade union representatives. Overall, however, it also became clear that it is not part of the fundamental

[5] Before the implementation of the National Qualifications Framework (Marco Nacional de Cualificaciones de la Educación y Formación Técnica Profesional de Costa Rica, MNC-EFTP-CR), the qualification was called técnico medio.

understanding of employers to be actively involved in VET or to participate in the designing of examinations. At the same time, some ministry employees have difficulties involving other stakeholders in the organisation of vocational education and training and the examination system. This could be due to the fact that the involvement of other stakeholders contradicts the common practice of centralised control of examination development and execution. Another reason could be that there are few links with the business sector in full-time school VET programmes. This could increase the barrier to collaboration in dual programmes. In addition, the fragmentation of the business sector makes it more difficult to involve further companies in dual VET.

6 Conclusion and outlook

The social acceptance of VET is always related to the respective context and access mechanisms to the labour market. Thus, VET and such programmes and certificates appear to be the second-best choice in Costa Rica at best compared to general and tertiary education. Stakeholders, particularly employers, express dissatisfaction with the vocational education and training that has only been taught in vocational schools to date. They see a skills mismatch between the qualifications taught at school and the competences required in the workplace. As a result, the qualifications that have been common up to now are not considered hard currency in the labour market. They seem not to amortise, neither for employers nor for qualified technicians. This is mainly because access to gainful employment in Costa Rica is more likely to be achieved through social contacts than through formally acquired professional qualifications. Apart from the content and competencies imparted, VET certificates are also legitimised within a society through social attribution.

Up to now, the development and implementation of VET programmes and the corresponding final exams in Costa Rica have been the sole responsibility of the MEP. As part of the development and execution of the newly implemented dual training programmes, the MEP is attempting to involve other stakeholders. However, it is currently unclear which stakeholders should be involved and to what extent. Full participation based on the consensus principle, as is the case in Germany, for example, could change the collective perception structures within Costa Rican society in the future. The involvement of actors from the private economy, in particular, could contribute to this to a large extent, as their function as gatekeepers puts them in a position of power. After all, they usually regulate access to gainful employment (Struck, 2001).

Such participation could specifically achieve collective acceptance and an appropriate exchange value of VET certificates in the Costa Rican labour market. This consideration should be investigated in a long-term study.

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Biographical notes

Claudia Hunink, a research associate at the University of Osnabrück, specializes in international comparative TVET research and youth transitions. She's currently involved in the CoRiCert project, supported by Germany's Ministry of Education and Science, focused on vocational training in Costa Rica.